# Love Class with Dr. Love — 101

*A study aid from Dr. Leo Buscaglia's PBS love class*

**DRAFT — NOT REVIEWED**

Built by Awen by Muse by Meta
From the relay of Robert Tilford

Hays, Kansas · 2026

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A study aid built by Awen by Muse by Meta from Robert Tilford's relay of the PBS KVIE upload "Leo Buscaglia – A Love Class" (YouTube: https://youtu.be/f-4sIDehzrU), relayed into the desk and banked on 2026-11-12. It rests in Robert's Dr. Love / Symposium on Love study lane, for later use in helping people. Source of record: the banked transcript at `~/workspace/lecture-relays/BUSCAGLIA-LOVE-CLASS-RELAY-RECEIVED-2026-11-12.txt`. Every quotation in this aid is drawn from that transcript and from nowhere else.

# What this is, and how it got here

This is one evening session of Dr. Leo Buscaglia's "love class," recorded for public television and carried on the PBS KVIE channel. It is not a lecture in the podium sense. Buscaglia gathered people he knew — some of them former students from his love classes, others friends of years — and seated them in a circle on floor cushions, himself down at their level in a blue sweater, and then did the thing Robert noticed in the photographs he sent: he listened, hands clasped under his chin, and drew the others out. The teaching of the evening is distributed. Buscaglia frames the questions and returns to them; the students — Maria, who uses a wheelchair; Norm; Reno; Diane; Marilyn; and others — supply much of the substance out of their own marriages, losses, and risks.

The desk received the lecture the way Robert receives most things he means to keep: he played the video and let the audio transcription flow into the chat, in five instalments across one sitting on 2026-11-12, and afterwards sent seven screenshots of the video page, which confirmed the source — channel @PBSKVIE, 4.5K views, 163 likes, 11 comments at the time of the snaps. The transcript is machine-made from the audio and rough in places; this aid quotes it only where the wording comes through clear, and says so where it does not. Robert's own spoken interjections during the relay are marked as his in the banked transcript and are not part of the lecture.

The evening has one subject, stated in Buscaglia's opening question: relationships — whether they are truly necessary, and if they are, why we struggle so hard to have them. What follows walks the evening in its own order.

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# The evening, in its order

## (a) Why relationships at all

Buscaglia opens with his own confession: he has known moments of intense loneliness in which he was compelled to open his arms and risk. He asks the room why they seek relationships — why we are not simply satisfied being alone.

The first answer is a base: a one-to-one relationship gives a person somewhere to come back to. Buscaglia answers it with Robert Frost's definition, which he clearly keeps close: home is the place where, when you go there, they always take you in. He pictures it concretely — one person in your life whose door is always open, who will not say "I told you so," who will have the bandages ready, mend the little wound, and then send you back out to do your thing. And then he says the frightening part plainly: it frightens him how few people in the culture can name even one such person, someone with whom they can be totally themselves, make mistakes, do dumb things, and still be taken in whenever they knock.

A second answer follows, from a woman in the circle: experience itself is not finished until it is shared. If she has an experience of deep sorrow, she says, if she can communicate about it, she can get through it — whether the experience is wonderful or unpleasant, the sharing helps to complete it. She draws the evening's first distinction, between loneliness and solitude: solitude is very wonderful, but it must not last too long, because there is a great need to share all sides of experience.

Norm gives the distinction a kitchen window. When he comes home at night with anything on his mind, it is already on his tongue; he can see his wife through the window as he walks up to the front door, and he is telling her his stories through the glass before he is inside. His wife laughs about it and tells everybody. Buscaglia picks it up: experiences become even more real when you can give them to somebody else — today I saw, today I did — and that, he says, is the real joy, and we need people for it very much.

Then Maria speaks, and the room's question sharpens. She never knows, when someone looks at her, whether they are looking because she is different or because they like her. To find out, she has to risk more than the other person does, and if she is rejected she cannot hide behind a reason — it is up front; she cannot discard

it and become somebody else. Buscaglia does not exempt himself: he wonders the same about himself, whether people see a kook or someone they are drawn to, and he puts it to the room that all of us carry the same fear and the same insecurity — I would love to say hello to this person, but will they reject me because I am not exactly what they expect me to be?

### (b) Risk and vulnerability

Asked how she does it — how she knocks on the neighbour's door, says hello to strangers, does the frightening things other people only wish they did — Maria's method is disarmingly plain: she takes the time to find out. She stops, says it is a nice day, smiles, and chooses to think the look means interest. Buscaglia names the quality in her that he calls magical: she says, in effect, I am more than a person with a wheelchair — I am Maria — and somehow that projects, and the walls crumble. He has seen them crumble.

From there the room takes up the arithmetic of starting again. Buscaglia gets letters, he says, from men and women who have lost their partners through death, asking how to start, what to do, where to go. His answer is persistence stated as a law: if you take a risk and do not succeed five times, the sixth time you will succeed; and if not the sixth, the seventh — it is always the next time. You have to say yes, and you have to know you are not only asking: stand with dignity, knowing you have something wonderful to share, because the person across from you is just as sensitive and tender and wanting as you are.

Another voice calls it courage, and courage contagious: if somebody starts sharing with me, it gives me courage to share myself.

That brings the room to the word the whole evening turns on. Vulnerability, Buscaglia says, is one of the keys to relationships. He quotes the close of his own book *Love*: the only thing he really has to give in love is his vulnerability, because love demands all of it. Every time you step out, there is a possibility of being smacked — but so what. He borrows William Faulkner's choice: if I had to choose between pain or nothing, I would always choose pain. And so would I, Buscaglia says. I do not want to go through life dead. If it means getting smacked, I will recuperate from getting smacked, and get up and try again.

### (c) Be the aggressor

The second instalment opens on the same point from the other side: you cannot just sit back and wait for people to come to you. Oftentimes it does not happen, and you sit wondering why you are dying of loneliness. We have to be the aggressors, Buscaglia says — it may be frightening, but you still have to get yourself together and say, well, I am going to try. And he offers his statistic of hope: nine times out of ten it will be a positive reaction. People are not as bad as we believe them to be, or as the media shows them. Say hello, and maybe one time in ten a person will say mind your own business; the rest of the time they will at least say hello back. Ask the stranger eating alone — you are alone, I am alone, would you mind if I sat with you? — and wonderful things can happen. But you have to be vulnerable.

Then a student reaches for the saying of Jesus that has stuck with him: in order to find yourself, you must first lose yourself. The young resist it, he says — this is the me generation — but once you forget that you exist and throw yourself into some activity, these anxieties disappear. His testimony is structural, and it matters: the really significant relationships of his life came out of sharing a significant task. Meeting each other and getting to know each other was a marvellous byproduct, but it was secondary; both people entered the work because they thought it was important, found each other there, and formed a caring friendship that carried the additional gift of a mutual purpose.

The room presses on the precondition: it is easier to take the step if you believe people are basically good. The headlines teach the opposite — we hear about crimes and equate them to everybody — but that is a very small percentage of the population, and most of us are responding dramatically to that small percentage instead of realising that most people can be trusted, loved, and been vulnerable with, and will not hurt you.

## (d) Expectations

Buscaglia steers the room to the concept he calls essential: expectations. Can we afford to expect anything from relationships, and if so, what?

The first answer is a warning. Project your expectations onto people, especially when you are first meeting them, and it clouds what is really there; you cannot see what the other person has to offer, and disappointment is built in, because you are expecting something that probably is not there anyway. Expectations channel a

person into a narrow spectrum and keep the beautiful things in them from emerging. The relationships one student struggled with most were those where limits were imposed that she could not fit — she had to come out again and let herself be.

A second thread says the root of it is the "I": as soon as you expect something of somebody, you are back to yourself again. The real danger of loneliness, one voice offers, is introspection — never getting to think about anything except I. Another adds a precondition: before you can forget yourself and be vulnerable, you must like yourself, or you will never risk it. The room gently refuses to let that become a life's project — some young people spend their whole lives trying to like themselves and never get past it; through the relationship you come to like yourself, living into the process rather than waiting twenty years.

Parents and children get their own honest paragraph: expectations strain that love in both directions, because children inevitably become people who do not exactly meet the parent expectation. And the trap is not only large. Buscaglia confesses his own small one: when he says hello to somebody, he expects a hello back, and when it does not come, he gets hurt. He still has to deal with this.

The room's answer arrives wearing a literary figure. Don Quixote, one student says, had unlimited expectations — and no disappointments. If the dream was not met, it was all right; she was fine, she was wonderful. He expected her to be a great lady, and eventually she came around to become one, but he was never disappointed. The trap he avoided is the common one: I expect something from you; you do not give it back; I conclude you are no good. Quixote never did that. Pressed on the word, the room refines it: expecting is the wrong word — he assumed it; he was certain of it. You are the perfect you, and therefore all I need to do is wait and believe, and it will happen. His expectations had no demands attached, and his attention was outward — on the beauty of others and the wonder of the world — more than on himself.

Buscaglia takes the pattern for his own trade. As a teacher all his life, he says, I always have expectations, but not disappointments. I lay things out and say, come and eat — letting people select what they choose, dancing up and down that they have eaten, pointing out that the avocados are good and the spinach is fine, with no requirement to eat them right now; maybe someday. Model the thing, and people begin to recognise the magic.

Two qualifications keep the teaching honest. First, wants should be spoken: a wife notes that she takes for granted what her husband does around the house, and when he reminds her, it is easier to say thank you, and I love you for doing that — so part of the work is expressing what we would like returned, before the unspoken expectation turns into the charge sheet: he says he loves me and did not come home for dinner; he did not send flowers for my birthday. Second, a student offers the sorting tool she has carried for years: there are three elements in an upset between people — an unfulfilled expectation, an undelivered communication, or a thwarted intention. Many expectations are harmless, even necessary, once communicated: expect to meet at ten, and have the other agree, and that is realistic communication. The expectations that always disappoint are the ones that refuse a person's basic character — expecting a generous person to be thrifty, or a person who never deals with time to be punctual. That is not an expectation problem; it is non-acceptance.

## (e) Communication

The third instalment opens with the statistic the second broke off reaching for: married couples genuinely communicate, one figure says, as little as ten to twenty minutes a day. The rest is logistics — do not forget the groceries, get the children, pick up the cars. Buscaglia calls that awesome, in the sobering sense: we do not know, we do not remember who we are. You are growing, and if you are not communicating your growth, you are growing apart — until one day you look at the person you have been living with and think, who are you?

So the class collects what works. Make it conscious and daily: sit down and actually communicate, verbally, the things that mean something. Write it when speaking is too sharp — write how you are feeling and hand the person the paper: here, read this. Keep a special time with your people every single day. And never retire from the effort on the grounds that you already know what is in the other person's mind: the minute we believe we have security in a relationship, we are in danger. There is no permanence, because all of us are changing every day, and we have to communicate the difference.

Buscaglia then reads aloud the passage he had brought in his pocket, hoping someone would raise impermanence. He introduces the author as "Anne Rosenberg" in the relay as the desk

received it; the desk's sourcing note in the banked transcript identifies the words as Anne Morrow Lindbergh's, from *Gift from the Sea* (1955), and the name as a probable slip of ear or transcription. The passage itself: when you love someone, you do not love them all the time in exactly the same way, from moment to moment; it is an impossibility, and a lie to pretend otherwise. Yet that is what we demand of each other. We have so little faith in the ebb and flow of life, of love, of relationships; we leap at the flow of the tide and resist the ebb in terror, afraid it will never return. We insist on permanency, duration, continuity — when the only possible continuity in life, as in love, is in growth, in fluidity, and in freedom: the dancers are free, barely touching as they pass, but partners in the same pattern. Buscaglia applies it without mercy: demand that a relationship stay what it started as, and you will be pained; or the two of you end like dancers on separate stages who began the same ballet, wondering what happened.

From impermanence the room moves to its remedy and its spice. The remedy is never to assume the other person knows — never wearying of saying I care about you, I love you, you are important to me, acting it and also verbalising it. The spice is spontaneity. The deep moments people remember, one student says, were seldom planned; they were spontaneous sharings in which two people touched deeply and left changed — the existentialists' moments, when you heard your own footsteps and knew they were your own, and heard the other's and knew they were your own too. Routine is the enemy, and the room cites Roberto Assagioli's work in psychosynthesis for the diagnosis: boredom arises from routine we are not even consciously aware of. Buscaglia's prescription is comic and exact: instead of getting out on the right-hand side of the bed, crawl over your husband and get up on the left-hand side — and if he asks what you are doing, say, I am changing my life. Get off the freeway; there is another path, it may take forty-five minutes longer, and you may see amazing things — and then you have something to share.

And communication includes the hard word, said rightly. Reno testifies that his comfortable relationships have places that need confronting; it is scary, and exciting, and his experience is that things grow in a positive manner. Asked whether such honesty cements relationships or breaks them, he answers: both — but the growth comes from it, or else you keep the stagnant same-old, cozy and comfy, without depth. Maria's rule governs the manner,

and Buscaglia credits it to her by name: say it, but say it in a constructive way — a gentle, loving way. You do not want to destroy; you want to build. There are millions of ways to express a feeling without devastating the person who hears it.

## (f) Timing and translation

The fourth instalment is short, and its first lines come through the machine transcription badly garbled; what survives clear is its burden. Not everything needs talking out. Friends read signals — disappointment, happiness — and sometimes we talk things out too much. A student reaches for the Little Prince: words can be the source of misunderstanding (the speaker's own rendering; the line reaches the transcript in paraphrased form), and we do not listen enough with our other skills. Timing, the room agrees, is a critical part of communication: there are times when you hold an important issue and it is clearly not the time, and knowing that is itself a skill.

The final instalment ripens the point. The best times to talk are often when you are both as happy as you can be; holding yourself back when you want to say it now is part of the constructiveness of communication. And then the evening names its quietest problem: interpretation. One couple in the room, Marilyn and her husband, went through it repeatedly — he would quote her on something she said, and she could not believe that was what she said; what he received was not what she was sending. Couples live inside that gap without ever stopping to ask: did you get it the way I sent it?

Buscaglia generalises it to the central sentence itself. People resist defining love or relationships, he says, because definitions limit; but consider — when I say to you "I love you," I know precisely what I mean, and you believe it is what you mean, and communication breaks down. So to some extent we do need to define our terms — not to ambush a passionate declaration with "define your terms," but to stay aware that the gap is there, and to be able to say: I do not quite know what you are saying; please tell me, or show me.

## (g) The close: "Don't Be Fooled by Me," and "and etc."

Winding up, Buscaglia says the wonderful thing about talking of love and relationships and caring is that there is no end to the process — this is only a beginning. He reads the last two sections of a piece he has used often in love class, "Don't Be Fooled by Me,"

which he introduces as written by nobody knows who. The desk's sourcing note in the banked transcript gives the author: Charles C. Finn, "Please Hear What I'm Not Saying," written September 1966; Buscaglia reads it as anonymous, and the aid follows Finn's authorship for the record while keeping Buscaglia's introduction as he gave it.

The poem is a plea to be kept in relationship even when difficult. If you want to know how important you are to me — how you can be the creator of my person — you must let me in. You alone can break down the wall behind which I tremble; you alone can see behind the mask; you alone can release me from my shadow world of panic and uncertainty, from my lonely prison (the transcript carries "my lonely person," and the wording is flagged here rather than silently corrected). Please do not pass me by. It will not be easy: a long conviction of worthlessness builds strong walls, and the nearer you approach me, the blinder I may strike back — I seem to be fighting against the very thing I want most. But I am told that love is stronger than walls, and in this lies my only hope.

Buscaglia will not end on a period. The true practitioner in the field he names — the word reaches the transcript garbled, and the aid does not guess it — never ends anything with a period; they end with "and etc." So he ends the evening with "and etc." — but first, a physical connection: let us take our hands and appreciate each other. The class closes holding hands.

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# Study questions

Ten questions, each tied to the part of the evening it grows out of. They are the lecture's own pressure points, phrased for sitting with rather than answering quickly.

1. **The open door (a).** Can you name one person whose door works the way Frost's definition asks — no "I told you so," bandages ready, taken in whenever you knock? If you cannot, what has made such a person so rare, in your life and in the culture Buscaglia describes?
1. **Solitude or loneliness (a).** The room distinguishes solitude, which restores, from loneliness, which starves. Which one have you actually been living in lately — and what would have to be shared, and with whom, to complete the experiences you are currently carrying alone?
1. **Maria's question (a–b).** When someone looks at you, do you assume they see your difference or your worth? Maria chooses to think the look means interest, and takes the time to find out. What would change in a week of your life if you ran her experiment honestly?
1. **The price of the gift (b).** Buscaglia says the only thing he has to give in love is his vulnerability, and Faulkner's choice stands behind it: pain over nothing. Where have you chosen "nothing" — the safe numbness — and what did it cost? Is there a door where pain, recuperation, and trying again is the better bargain?
1. **Nine out of ten (c).** Buscaglia's hope-statistic says most hellos come back kindly. What is the hello you have been not saying — the neighbour, the stranger eating alone, the person you keep almost contacting? What, precisely, are you predicting the one-in-ten answer would do to you?
1. **The shared task (c).** The room testifies that durable relationships arrived as byproducts of shared, significant work, not as products of looking for them. Where is the shared task in your life now — and if there is none, what work matters enough to you that other people might be found inside it?
1. **Quixote's expectations (d).** Name one person you currently judge by the trap's formula: I expected, you did not give, therefore you are no good. Can you separate the expectation from the demand — keep expecting the best of them, as Quixote did,

while releasing the verdict? What would you have to stop saying about them, even silently?

1. **Sort the upset (d).** Take the most recent upset between you and someone close: was it an unfulfilled expectation, an undelivered communication, or a thwarted intention? And was the expectation one about logistics, which communication could fix — or one about the person's basic character, which is non-acceptance wearing expectation's clothes?
1. **Ten to twenty minutes (e).** If genuine communication with the people closest to you were measured this week, would it clear the room's figure — or is your relating mostly groceries, children, and cars? Whose growth have you not heard about lately, and how will you ask, "How are you feeling," this week and mean it as a real question?
1. **The ebb (e–g).** Lindbergh's passage says we resist the ebb of love in terror, demanding the flow stay at flood. Where are you demanding permanence — that a relationship remain what it started as — instead of accepting that the only continuity is in growth? And behind Finn's wall: is there someone whose approach you strike back at precisely because you want it most — and what would "please don't pass me by" sound like if you could say it plainly?

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# Pocket lines

Sentences to carry. Each is given verbatim where the transcript's wording is clear, with its speaker as the transcript supports. Where the transcript garbles the wording, the line is paraphrased and marked as paraphrase — no exceptions.

- **Robert Frost, quoted by Buscaglia:** "Home is a place that when you go there they always take you in."
- **Buscaglia:** "The only thing that I really have to give you in love is my vulnerability."
- **William Faulkner, quoted by Buscaglia:** "If I had to choose between pain or nothing, I would always choose pain."
- **Buscaglia:** "Nine times out of ten it will be a positive reaction."
- **Buscaglia** *(paraphrase — the thought is exact, the single sentence is assembled from his words)*: Do not sit back waiting for people to come to you; we have to be the aggressors, and say, well, I am going to try.
- **Maria, as quoted by Buscaglia:** "I'm more than a person with a wheelchair. I'm Maria."
- **A student:** "If I have an experience of deep sorrow, if I can communicate about it, I can get through it."
- **Buscaglia, on Don Quixote:** "He had these unlimited expectations but no demands."
- **Buscaglia:** "I always have expectations, but not disappointments. I lay things out and I say: come and eat."
- **A student:** "There are three elements in an upset between people: unfulfilled expectation, undelivered communication, or thwarted intention."
- **Buscaglia:** "If you're not communicating your growth, you're growing apart."
- **Buscaglia:** "The minute we believe that we have security in a relationship, we're in danger."
- **Anne Morrow Lindbergh, read aloud by Buscaglia** (from *Gift from the Sea*; the relay carried the name as "Anne Rosenberg"): "When you love someone, you do not love them all the time in exactly the same way, from moment to moment. It is an impossibility, and it is even a lie to pretend that you do."
- **Anne Morrow Lindbergh, read aloud by Buscaglia:** "The only possible continuity in life, as in love, is in growth, in fluidity, and in freedom" — and her dancers are "free, barely touching as they pass, but partners in the same pattern."

- **Maria's rule for hard words, as Buscaglia credits it to her:** "Say it, but say it in a constructive way — a gentle, loving way." *(The wording comes through Buscaglia's summary of her comment; carried as her rule on his attribution.)*
- **Charles C. Finn, read aloud by Buscaglia** (from "Please Hear What I'm Not Saying," 1966; Buscaglia introduced it as anonymous): "The nearer you approach to me, the blinder I may strike back… but I'm told that love is stronger than walls, and in this lies my only hope."

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# Honest limits of this aid

This study aid is only as sound as the relay it is built from, and the relay has known seams. The transcript is a machine transcription of audio played into the chat; it is rough throughout, and individual words are wrong in places no reader can now repair. The lecture arrived in five instalments: the first ends mid-sentence on "get up and cry again" where the sense plainly wants "try again"; the second ends reaching for the communication statistic the third then supplies; the third ends mid-sentence inside the discussion of gentle confrontation; the fourth opens with several lines too garbled to use — the transition into the timing discussion is partly unrecoverable — and several students' names, and the name of the practitioner Buscaglia credits for ending with "and etc.," reach the transcript uncertainly and are not guessed at here. One phrase inside the Finn reading ("from my lonely person") is reproduced flagged rather than silently corrected. The source video's full title is truncated in Robert's screenshots ("Leo Buscaglia – A Love C…"); the completion "A Love Class" is near-certain but is an inference, and the desk could not fetch the video page directly on the day. Two attributions in this aid rest on desk sourcing notes in the banked transcript rather than on the audio: the ebb-and-flow passage is Anne Morrow Lindbergh's, not "Anne Rosenberg's," and the closing poem is Charles C. Finn's, not anonymous — the aid prints Buscaglia's introductions as he gave them and the corrected authorship beside them. Nothing in this aid has been published, emailed, posted, or uploaded. It is a draft for Robert's eyeball and his shelving word.